



Cerkl |  Broadcast

The Hidden Cost of Benefits Communication

Matt Frost on benefits communication in 2026 —
compliance, clarity, and proving it worked.

From compliance to connection

\$30K

Avg US benefits spend per employee, per year

Most employees can't connect the dollars being spent on their behalf to what's actually in the plan.

90%

Of benefits communication comes from vendors

Their branding, their narrative — the company funds the benefit, and the vendor takes the credit.

84M

US employees, plus 74M dependents on the plan

Roughly half of plan members aren't employees — and almost no team is communicating with them.



STAGE 1

Compliance

We communicate because we have to, and the result reads like a legal notice. Most teams stay parked here.



STAGE 2

Clarity

Time taken to explain the what, when, and why — written for the employee, not the approval chain.



STAGE 3

Relevance

The same message in different shapes, segmented by life stage, role, and geography so it lands.



STAGE 4

Connection

Benefits become tangible proof of the EVP — the receipt of the promise, not just the promise itself.

"Companies are already paying for benefits. Communication is the difference between whether that spend is seen as an investment, or just a cost."

— Matt Frost, closing manifesto

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